

Messi, Odysseus, and the End of the Hero

The hardest part of a great journey may not be winning.
It may be knowing when to leave the centre of the story.

ESSAY By The Philosophy of Now

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When the final whistle sounded at the 2026 World Cup, two stories appeared on the same field.

One belonged to Spain, the new champion. After more than 100 minutes without a goal, substitute Ferran Torres scored in extra time to secure a 1-0 victory over Argentina. Spain's triumph was built less around a single superstar than around collective control, patience and depth.

The other story belonged to Lionel Messi.

At 39, Messi had reached yet another World Cup final. He had already won the tournament four years earlier and completed almost every possible chapter in a footballer's career. This time, however, the ending belonged to someone else. The cameras captured the disappointment of a man whose extraordinary World Cup journey may now be complete.

On the same weekend, audiences around the world were watching another aging hero attempt to return home. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey*, starring Matt Damon as Odysseus, opened in cinemas with US\$264.1 million in worldwide ticket sales.

One hero stood at the end of a football career. Another sailed home after a war.

Together, they raise a question that eventually confronts every successful person:

“What happens when the world no longer needs you to be its hero?”

The hero who cannot stop travelling

Odysseus spends ten years fighting in the Trojan War and another ten trying to return to Ithaca.

His journey contains monsters, shipwrecks, temptations and angry gods. But beneath the adventure lies a surprisingly ordinary human struggle: Odysseus repeatedly risks losing sight of where he is going.

The island of the Lotus-Eaters offers comfortable forgetfulness. Circe offers pleasure. Calypso offers love and even immortality. The Sirens promise irresistible knowledge and recognition.

Each temptation gives Odysseus a reason not to return home.

This is what makes *The Odyssey* more than a story about travel. It is a story about a man learning that movement is not always progress.

We often assume that heroes are defined by their willingness to continue. They fight one more battle, accept one more mission and attempt one more impossible achievement.

But Odysseus is ultimately saved by something different: his ability to remember that the journey has a destination.

He is not trying to travel forever. He is trying to return.

Success creates its own trap

The desire to remain the hero is understandable.

A founder builds a company from nothing. Every major decision passes through her. Her instincts created its culture, attracted its first customers and carried it through crises.

Then the company grows.

It needs systems rather than improvisation. It needs leaders who think differently from its founder. But stepping back feels like abandonment. The founder may tell herself that nobody else is ready.

Sometimes that is true.

Sometimes “nobody else is ready” means “I am not ready to become less important.”

The same pattern appears in families. A parent spends decades protecting a child, solving problems and giving advice. Eventually, the child becomes an adult. The parent's task must change from directing a life to respecting one.

But advice can be difficult to surrender. Being needed has become part of the parent's identity.

It also appears in leadership. A senior executive continues to dominate every meeting because silence feels like disappearance. A former champion competes past the point of joy because applause has become inseparable from self-worth. An investor holds on to yesterday's winning idea because changing his mind feels like losing part of himself.

The achievement that creates our identity can eventually imprison it.

Odysseus confronts many monsters, but the most dangerous possibility is that he might become permanently attached to being the wandering hero.

The difference between purpose and attention

Messi's greatness was never based merely on scoring goals. He changed how people understood space, movement and possibility on a football field.

Yet even the greatest athlete cannot remain at the centre forever.

A new generation always arrives. Teammates take on larger roles. Young players become the faces children imitate. The game continues - not because the former hero was unimportant, but because no individual, however brilliant, can permanently own a living tradition.

This can sound cruel. It can also be liberating.

If our value depends on receiving attention, then aging becomes a form of disappearance. Every younger colleague becomes a threat. Every change becomes evidence that the world is forgetting us.

But purpose and attention are not the same.

Attention asks:

Are people still looking at me?

Purpose asks:

What can exist because I was here?

The first question makes succession frightening. The second makes it meaningful.

A great founder does not merely build a successful company. The founder builds a company capable of surviving its founder.

A great teacher does not produce permanent followers. The teacher produces independent minds.

A great parent does not remain indispensable. The parent helps another person become free.

A great athlete leaves more than records. He leaves standards, memories and possibilities that younger players can extend.

Legacy begins when influence no longer requires control.

Returning home

Odysseus does not return to Ithaca as the same man who left.

Homecoming is not a restoration of the past. Twenty years have passed. His son has grown up. His wife has endured a life of uncertainty. His kingdom has changed, and so has he.

To return home, Odysseus must accept a new identity.

This may be the final test of every hero: not whether he can defeat one more enemy, but whether he can live without needing another enemy to defeat.

Modern life constantly encourages us to keep travelling. There is always another promotion, acquisition, award, audience or milestone. We tell ourselves that contentment will arrive after

the next victory.

But the next victory creates another horizon.

Without a clear idea of home - of what all the striving is for - we may become highly successful wanderers.

Home does not have to mean retirement or withdrawal. It may mean becoming a mentor instead of the main performer. It may mean choosing family over another title. It may mean allowing someone younger to lead. It may simply mean discovering that our identity is larger than the activity in which we became successful.

The hero does not have to disappear.

But he must learn how to stop occupying every scene.

The final victory

Spain lifted the trophy. Argentina accepted defeat. A younger generation moved further into the light, while one of football's greatest figures moved closer to the edge of the stage.

But leaving the centre does not erase the journey.

Odysseus's greatness lies not only in surviving the sea. It lies in remembering why he crossed it.

Perhaps this is also the final responsibility of leadership: to recognize that the purpose of reaching the summit is not to remain there forever. It is to see more clearly what should come next - and to help others continue the journey.

The last victory of the hero may therefore be the quietest one.

Not conquering another kingdom.

Not winning another trophy.

Not hearing the crowd say his name again.

But being able to step away without believing that his meaning has stepped away with him.

Is a great life measured by how long we remain at the centre - or by what continues after we leave it?

SOURCES NOTE

Context for the opening scene: World Cup final match reporting and film-industry box-office reporting. Philosophical background: Homer, *The Odyssey*. The article text is preserved from the supplied conversation; factual references should be independently verified before publication.